

Turning pro

In a pioneering effort, Jadavpur University has endorsed the achievement of underprivileged young people who completed a basic course in automobile tailoring and sewing.

Neelanjana Gautam reports

KUDOS to the Department of Adult Continuing Education and Extension, Jadavpur University. It's thanks to them that some 21 underprivileged children have completed a basic course in automobile, tailoring and sewing. The university, in collaboration with Emmanuel Ministries, offered accreditation to these non-formal graduates under the University Grants Commission — an event that marked a paradigm shift in terms of societal parameters. "Elevated to university standards!" remarked West Bengal Governor Viren J Shah at a function in Raj Bhavan to celebrate the occasion.

Emmanuel Ministries, a frontrunner in child rights and developmental programmes, was the prime mover. As its executive director Vijayan Pavamani says, "Children are not junk, that you could dump them." The first step was to float the Pavement Club. "The main focus is to equip the boys and girls with basic life skills and practical hands-on training so that they can avert the dangers they are exposed to in adverse life situations," says Ashok Bhattacharya who heads ACEE.

While India ratified the UN adoption of universal legal standards for the protection and well-being of children, EMC affirms the worth and dignity of the legislation and facilitates a change in attitude, behaviour and lifestyle. Initially, the project was aimed at getting the guys off the street by giving them some basic learning, health check-ups and a nutritious snack. Today the children are happily studying for hours, performing at public



programmes, competing with mainstream students, working as peer educators, reaching out to distressed folks, conducting focus-group discussions and talking about migrant child labour.

"Self-reliance is the key!" Only children who have a certain sense of understanding and awareness come under the purview of the skill development scheme," says project coordinator Sharmistha Mukherjee. The age, naturally, stretches beyond the malleable limit of 16 and above. Also students have to be familiar with the technicalities of applying, therefore, have to attain a minimum expertise.

The Nilofers, Nazmas, Abduls and Rajens are exposed to harsh surroundings every time they step outside the classroom and the workshop. The contrast is sharply etched. "We enjoy coming here," says Nazma. "Picking up skills was a joy and will be a source of income later. It has given us a sense of fulfilment. And everyone is so loving and caring." Even as she is going gush-gush, a voice yells, "Hello Daddy!" The call is directed at 'Vijayan Pavamani!'

Though the final endorsement tag comes from Jadavpur University, EMC takes care of the infrastructure and instruction. Screened and experienced instructors have been roped in to ensure a quality education.

As for the kids, you only have to scratch the surface to see what sensible souls they have shaped up as.